Two Roads to a Pennant: Roster-Building Strategies for the 2027–29 Minnesota Twins

Prepared as a discussion brief for the OLLI course on the history of statistics and analytics in baseball — October 28, 2026

A Note on Assumptions and Honesty

This brief takes as given the two assumptions you specified: (1) the labor negotiations that begin when the current Collective Bargaining Agreement expires on December 1, 2026 produce no major changes to the game's economic rules, and (2) Twins ownership adds $20 million to its 2026 payroll, which FanGraphs estimates at about $111 million (FanGraphs Roster Resource). That puts the 2027 target at roughly **$131 million.**

Three honesty flags before we start:

- **Everything labeled "my estimate" or "my construction" is exactly that.** Contract figures for free agents, trade packages, and all probabilities below are reasoned judgments, not reported facts or model outputs. I show the reasoning so your students can attack it.
- **Trade proposals are illustrative, not reported negotiations.** The player names are grounded in published reporting and analyst assessments about who is plausibly available, but no source reports the Twins discussing these specific deals. Where a published article proposed a trade itself, I say so and attribute it.
- **The payroll arithmetic is the hidden lesson of this exercise.** As shown below, "$20 million more than 2026" does not mean "$20 million to spend on free agents," because arbitration raises and roster-fill costs consume most of the increase before a single new player is signed. Both strategies below are approximately budget-targeted rather than verified to the dollar: published 2027 baselines range from ~$111M to ~$126M depending on accounting conventions, and my ledgers carry roughly ±$2M of slack from roster-slot displacement effects.

1. Where the Twins Stand (October 2026)

The 2026 season

The Twins went 77–85 (.475), finishing third in the AL Central, eight games behind Cleveland (85–77), with Chicago's young White Sox (84–78) second and Detroit (76–86) fourth (MLB.com standings, Wikipedia). Their run differential (739 scored, 797 allowed) translated to an expected record of just 75–87, so the team was about as bad as its record (MLB.com standings, ESPN). It was their second straight losing season and third straight late-year collapse, this time driven by a pitching staff worn down by injuries and an under-invested bullpen (Axios). The season's defining event happened before it began: ace Pablo López suffered an elbow injury on the first

day of spring training and missed the entire year, though he avoided full Tommy John surgery (internal-brace procedure) and is targeting a return to spring training in 2027 (MLB Trade Rumors, Yardbarker).

The backdrop matters for your course: this was the Twins' lowest payroll in about a decade (roughly $105M on Opening Day, ~$111M final), following a 2025 fire sale in which the club purged 11 players at the trade deadline — including closer Jhoan Durán — and sent former Twin Griffin Jax to Tampa Bay in the deadline deal that brought Taj Bradley to Minnesota (Yardbarker, Bleacher Report). New controlling owner Tom Pohlad has promised to "meaningfully invest" in the 2027 payroll, saying "a $100 million payroll, or anything close to that, is not sufficient to be consistently competitive" (MLB.com, MLB Trade Rumors).

The 2027 payroll bridge — the most important table in this report

Item	Amount (2027)	Source basis
Guaranteed contracts: López $21.75M, Buxton $15.14M, Hoffman ~$7.25M net ($11M salary less Toronto's $3.75M), Caratini $6.5M	~$50.6M	FanGraphs payroll ledger; MLBTR offseason outlook
Payment to Houston (Correa trade)	$10.0M	FanGraphs payroll ledger
Buyouts (Bell $1.25M, Ryan $0.1M, Topa $0.025M)	~$1.4M	FanGraphs payroll ledger
Ten arbitration-eligible players at MLBTR projections: Ryan $9.6M, Ober $6.9M, Kremer $6.5M, Larnach $6.3M, plus Wallner, Lewis, Bradley, Clemens, Sands, Banda	~$47.3M	MLBTR Twins page
Pre-arbitration players and in-season roster fill (34+ player-seasons at the ~$780K minimum)	~$15–16M	Yahoo Sports full accounting
Status-quo 2027 baseline (no new players)	**~$126M**	Yahoo Sports

Published baselines vary with accounting conventions: FanGraphs' early 2027 ledger is ~$111M, Twins Daily's cash mapping is ~$115M counting only 26-man rookie salaries, and the fuller accounting that counts in-season depth reaches ~$126M (FanGraphs, Twins Daily, Yahoo Sports). I use the conservative ~$126M figure so that both strategies below are budgeted under a realistic reading; under the more optimistic conventions there is additional room. The key structural fact: the Twins can create meaningful additional room only by trading or non-tendering the one-year arbitration contracts of Trevor Larnach (~$6.3M), Bailey Ober (~$6.9M), and Dean Kremer (~$6.5M) — all free agents after 2027 (MLBTR).

Roster strengths and weaknesses

Strengths. A young, cheap, homegrown position-player core has already reached the majors: center fielder Byron Buxton (32) remains the star when healthy — 23 homers and a .937 OPS in his first 63 games per mid-season reporting, before September hip surgery ended his year — and around him the Twins have assembled the outfield of the future: Luke Keaschall (24, led the 2026 team in runs, hits, doubles, and steals while hitting .282/.374/.407), Emmanuel Rodriguez (23, left field), and Walker Jenkins (21, the former No. 5 overall pick, who hit .300/.389/.521 with 18 homers in 417 plate appearances across four minor- and major-league stops per MLB Pipeline — the source does not break out the major-league portion — before a minor elbow

cleanup) (Yardbarker, MLB.com, MLB Pipeline, MLBTR). Infielder Kaelen Culpepper (23) also reached the majors, and Kody Clemens was named team MVP after driving in 81 runs. The rotation has a high ceiling: López and Joe Ryan (3.17 ERA through 15 mid-season starts) at the top, Taj Bradley's breakout year, and young arms Connor Prielipp, Zebby Matthews, Mick Abel, and Kendry Rojas behind them (Yardbarker, MLB.com).

Weaknesses. (1) **No closer** — the Twins have been searching for one since trading Jhoan Durán; Yoendrys Gómez faded late and the club has roughly "two-thirds of a competent bullpen" (Yardbarker). (2) **Catcher** — Ryan Jeffers (.256/.353/.461, 14 HR in 92 games) is a free agent; only Victor Caratini ($6.5M) is under contract (CBS Sports, MLBTR). (3) **First base/DH power** — Josh Bell's $10M mutual option will likely be declined after a modest .255/.319/.419 season (MLBTR). (4) **Second base / corner-infield uncertainty** around Royce Lewis's stalled development.

The farm system

The system is deep in position players, especially catchers. MLB Pipeline's 2026 top five are Jenkins, catcher Vahn Lackey (A+, ETA 2029), shortstop Culpepper, shortstop Marek Houston (Double-A, ETA 2028, .312/.392/.455 with 50 steals in 2026), and Rodriguez — with Jenkins and Culpepper still technically prospect-ranked while playing in the majors (MLB.com, MLB.com). Behind them: pitching prospects Riley Quick, Dasan Hill, and Charlee Soto, catchers Eduardo Tait, Carson Tinney, Khadim Diaw and Ricardo Olivar, outfielders Hendry Mendez, Jhomnardo Reyes, Yasser Mercedes and Brandon Winokur, and 2026 organization pitcher of the year Adrian Bohorquez (MLB.com, Prospects Live, Twins Daily). This catching surplus is a genuine trade asset — few organizations can offer four credible catching prospects.

The competitive landscape

The AL is top-heavy: Tampa Bay (the pennant winner, with a bottom-tier payroll — a Strategy B poster child), Cleveland, the Yankees, Houston, Boston, and a rapidly improving young White Sox club that went from 102 losses in 2025 to 84 wins and a playoff series victory in 2026 behind Japanese import Munetaka Murakami (CBS Sports, MLB.com, CBS Sports). The AL Central itself is winnable — it was won with 85 games — but the White Sox and Guardians are young and rising, not fading.

2. Strategy A: "Go For It Now" — Maximize the 2027 Pennant Chance

Philosophy

Convert the $20M increment plus tradeable expiring contracts into immediate 2027 wins: a middle-of-the-order power bat who solves catcher/DH for three years, a real closer, and a left-handed reliever, while the cheap young core supplies the foundation. This is the classic "push the chips in" build, and it has precedent in Minnesota: the Twins' biggest-ever free-agent splashes (the two Correa signings) came in exactly this mode, and MLBTR's offseason outlook explicitly frames this winter as the club's most aggressive since those deals (MLBTR). One boundary condition worth naming for the class: the very top of this winter's market is out of reach. Ace Tarik Skubal is expected to challenge the $400M mark, and NPB Triple Crown winner

Teruaki Sato drew a 5-year, $180M projection in one report of Jim Bowden's forecast (Spotrac, Bolavip) — neither fits a $131M payroll. "Star power" at the Twins' scale means the second tier plus shrewd trades.

The moves

A1. Trade for Hunter Goodman, C/1B/DH, Colorado Rockies.
Goodman hit 41 home runs in 574 plate appearances in 2026 with three years of club control remaining (arbitration through 2029, projected ~$6.2M in 2027), and roughly 60% of his homers came on the road for the second straight year, which quieted the Coors Field discount (Bleacher Report, Bleacher Report). The Rockies have lost 100+ games four straight years, and B/R's analyst wrote that "nothing should be off the table" in Denver. He replaces Jeffers's bat at catcher/DH/first base for three years at bargain cost. **Illustrative opening package (my construction, not a reported negotiation): C Eduardo Tait (top-10 org. prospect — Colorado gets its catcher of the future), RHP Riley Quick, and OF Yasser Mercedes.** Be honest with the class: the same analyst judged the asking price "high," so this package may not be enough.

A2. Sign free-agent closer David Bednar, RHP (3 years, ~$40M — my estimate).
Bednar, 32, posted a 2.47 ERA with 35 saves for the Yankees in 2026 (Yahoo Sports). This fills the team's most persistent hole. It would also break an organizational taboo: the Twins haven't given a multi-year free-agent contract to a reliever since Addison Reed in 2018 — something Twins Daily's "bold predictions" piece says is precisely the move that would signal seriousness (Twins Daily). **Fallback:** 37-year-old Raisel Iglesias (Braves) on a shorter deal, or a trade for San Diego's Mason Miller — controlled through 2029 at ~$8.1M, though the B/R analyst's assessment of the likely cost is an elite-prospect headliner the Twins would struggle to match without touching Jenkins (Bleacher Report).

A3. Sign free-agent lefty reliever JoJo Romero (~2 years, ~$8M total — my estimate).
Romero was named by Twins beat coverage as the left-handed bullpen target in free agency (Yahoo Sports). The 2026 bullpen collapsed largely because the late innings were thin; this is the cheap second bullpen add.

A4. Extend a qualifying offer to Ryan Jeffers — and treat it as a budget branch, not a free option.
Jeffers is QO-eligible (CBS Sports), and MLBTR expects the Twins to make the offer (Spotrac). The honest framing has two branches:

- **He declines (the expected case):** the Twins get a compensatory draft pick if he signs elsewhere, and the primary ledger below stands as written.
- **He accepts (a real possibility for a player coming off an injury-shorted year in a thin catching market):** the club carries a catcher at a one-year salary likely above $20M. The primary package no longer fits. The acceptance branch looks like this: no Goodman trade, no Bednar; instead Jeffers (~$23M, my estimate) plus Romero (~$4M) plus the Larnach-trade reliever, with the closer role filled internally or by a cheap one-year signing — roughly $131M, but a meaningfully worse team than the primary plan. That asymmetry is the risk of the QO: it is not a free option.

A5. Shed the expiring arbitration contracts to fund the additions.
Three separate moves, each grounded in reporting: (a) trade Trevor Larnach — the Twins had a deadline deal lined up sending him to Houston for reliever Bryan Abreu before Astros ownership killed it, so his market is real — for a pre-arbitration reliever (salary ~$1M; my construction) (MLBTR); (b) non-tender or trade Bailey Ober, whom MLBTR already flagged as a non-tender candidate (MLBTR); (c) trade Dean Kremer for prospects — both he and Ober were described by MLBTR as possible trade scenarios that would open rotation spots for younger pitchers (MLBTR). The 2027 rotation becomes López – Ryan – Bradley – Prielipp – Matthews, with Abel, Rojas, and Festa (returning from injury) as depth.

A6 (a published alternative worth discussing). Bleacher Report actually proposed a Twins-specific trade: outfielder Emmanuel Rodriguez, RHP Riley Quick, and infielder Ben Ross to Seattle for one year of right-hander Logan Gilbert (projected $15.4M in his walk year) (Bleacher Report). It is a legitimate win-now use of prospect capital — but note that in my judgment it is the least efficient version of going for it, because Rodriguez is exactly the young, cheap, controllable talent that makes a small-market push possible.

The payroll ledger (my construction, full accounting)

Move	Payroll effect
Status-quo 2027 baseline	~$126M
Trade Larnach; pre-ARB reliever returns	−$6.3M + $1.0M
Non-tender/trade Ober	−$6.9M
Trade Kremer for prospects	−$6.5M
Acquire Goodman	+$6.2M
Sign Bednar	+$13M
Sign Romero	+$4M
Total	**~$130.5M — approximately at the ~$131M ceiling**

Two caveats I want on the record. First, this ledger is approximately budget-targeted, not verified to the dollar: swapping players in and out displaces minimum-salary roster slots that the baseline already counted, worth roughly ±$2M, and the baseline itself depends on the accounting convention (see Section 1). Second, the quiet centerpiece of Strategy A: the free-agent money for Bednar and Romero does not exist until three expiring contracts are traded away. If you keep Kremer for rotation safety, the Bednar signing is what breaks the budget — every combination forces a choice.

What the 2027 team looks like, and the risks

Rotation: López (if healthy) – Ryan – Bradley – Prielipp – Matthews. Lineup: Buxton, Jenkins, Rodriguez, Keaschall, Culpepper, Brooks Lee, Clemens, Goodman (C/1B/DH), Caratini catching against righties. Bullpen: Bednar – Hoffman (returning from minor elbow surgery) – Gómez – Sands – Romero – the Larnach-trade reliever.

Remaining weaknesses and risks: the rotation is one López setback from trouble (the traded Kremer and Ober were the insurance); Buxton's health; Goodman's road-power profile regressing; Bednar's age curve; and the structural cost — the farm system is thinner after the Goodman trade, and after 2027 Ryan departs as a free agent and López's contract ends, so the 2028 retool must come from Prielipp/Matthews/Abel/Rojas and whatever the traded prospects become. Bednar and Goodman, at least, are controlled through 2029.

Probability of success (judgment estimate — not a model)

Reasoning, shown step by step:

1. **Status quo.** The 2026 team was a 75-win team by run differential that lost López (~4–5 WAR) for the whole year, lost most of September's Buxton to hip surgery, and debuted Jenkins, Rodriguez, and Culpepper late. A full year of a healthy López and Buxton plus full seasons from the young core, less some regression from 30-year-old Clemens's career year, projects (my judgment) to roughly **82–85 wins** — consistent with the front office's public expectation of contention (MLB.com). Note this baseline already includes the young core's internal growth; it is the status-quo estimate against which each strategy's transactions are measured.
2. **Strategy A's additions.** Goodman (+3 WAR versus a Caratini/depth baseline), Bednar (+1.5), Romero (+0.5), the Larnach-trade reliever (+0.5), minus the departures of Larnach, Ober, and Kremer (about −1.5 combined, with Matthews and Prielipp stepping in) — a net of roughly **+3 to +4 wins**, making an **86–88 win team**: a genuine division contender in a Central won at 85 games, but a wild card at best against Tampa Bay's tier.
3. **P(make the 2027 playoffs) ≈ 50–60%** (division plus wild card routes; the Guardians and White Sox are good, and the Yankees/Astros/Red Sox/Rangers block the wild card).
4. **P(win the AL pennant given a playoff berth) ≈ 10–14%** (the Rays are elite; October is high-variance).
5. **P(AL pennant in 2027) ≈ 5–8%.**
6. **2028–29.** Bednar and Goodman remain, but Ryan departs after 2027, López's contract ends, Buxton turns 33, and the farm is thinner. Pennant odds of roughly 5% (2028) and 4–5% (2029).
7. **P(at least one pennant in 2027–29).** If the three seasons were independent, $1 - (0.94 \times 0.95 \times 0.955) \approx 15\%$; I would state a range of **12–16%** and flag that the independence calculation is an illustration, not a truth: a healthy 2027 roster makes a healthy 2028 roster more likely, so the seasons are positively correlated and the "at least one" probability sits somewhat below the independent calculation.

3. Strategy B: "Build the Three-Year Core" — Maximize P(Pennant) over 2027–29

Philosophy

Keep the young core intact, extend it before it gets expensive, trade the expiring veteran assets at peak value for future talent, and time the payroll runoff to the arrival of the next prospect wave (Houston in 2028, Lackey in 2029). The contract clock matters here: López (~$21.75M) and Hoffman (~$7.25M net) come off after 2027 — about $29M gross — and Buxton ($15.1M) plus the final Correa payment ($10M) come off after 2028 — another ~$25M gross (FanGraphs, MLBTR). Those are gross reductions, not automatically spendable room: arbitration raises, extension raises, and the cost of replacing departing players consume part of them. As a working assumption shared by both strategies, I treat roughly half of each tranche as genuinely spendable under a flat nominal ~$131M ceiling in 2028–29. So the strategy is not "wait for a windfall"; it is a staged handoff — veterans' money rolls off in stages as the next cohort arrives. Spend the $20M increment on (a) acquisitions whose contracts span the whole window and (b) extensions that buy out arbitration years. Accept a modestly lower 2027 in exchange for a higher, longer 2028–29 plateau. This is, essentially, the Tampa Bay model — the team that just won the AL pennant with one of baseball's lowest payrolls by developing and extending young talent rather than buying veterans (CBS Sports).

The moves

B1. Trade Joe Ryan this winter — the signature move.
Ryan is B/R's #9 trade chip in all of baseball: a legitimate mid-rotation-or-better starter with one year of control at a reasonable $9.6M arbitration projection, and MLB.com reported the Cubs, Nationals, and White Sox among the fits at the deadline (Bleacher Report, MLB.com). **Illustrative ask (my construction): from the Cubs, right-hander Jaxon Wiggins (Triple-A, formerly MLB Pipeline's No. 58 overall prospect) plus outfielder Kane Kepley (Double-A)** — both names grounded in Chicago's current Pipeline rankings (MLB.com, MLB.com). Note the counterargument honestly: Twins beat coverage argues against trading Ryan because it opens an innings hole in the very season you are trying to stay credible (Yahoo Sports). That is the tension of Strategy B in one move: trading 2027 wins for 2028–29 wins.

B2. Trade for Reid Detmers, LHP, Angels — Ryan's replacement, with two years of control instead of one.
Detmers is B/R's #10 trade chip: a left-hander who finished among the AL's top 10 in strikeouts, innings pitched, and pitcher WAR in 2026, controlled through 2028 at ~$7.5M, on a franchise B/R described as long overdue for a rebuild (Bleacher Report, CBS Sports). **The price honesty: two years of a top-10-AL pitcher costs more than one year of Ryan brings back.** B/R's comparable benchmark is the Corbin Burnes and Freddy Peralta trades, which returned an MLB-ready pitching prospect and a position-player prospect ranked around No. 100 overall for one year of control; Detmers has two years, so the ask is plausibly higher. My proposed limit (my construction): the better of the two prospects returned for Ryan — Wiggins — plus outfielder Hendry Mendez, and nothing beyond that. If Anaheim demands more, walk away and fill Ryan's rotation slot internally with Prielipp or Matthews (see B7). Detmers is an upgrade, not a dependency.

B3. Extend the young core now — the heart of the strategy.
GM Jeremy Zoll has already said the club will look into extending its promising younger players

(MLBTR). Service-time arithmetic (from the FanGraphs ledger) drives the structure of each deal:

- **Walker Jenkins (OF, 21, roughly 0.05 service years after 2026):** controlled through about 2033, so a long deal buys out arbitration plus the first free-agent years. The model contract is Corbin Carroll's pre-arbitration extension with Arizona — 8 years, $111M with a club option, signed in 2023 after just 32 major-league games (ESPN, MLB.com). A Twins-scale version (my estimate, smaller because Jenkins has no established major-league track record and is coming off minor elbow surgery): 8 years, ~$65–80M with a club option.
- **Luke Keaschall (0.164 service), Kaelen Culpepper, Emmanuel Rodriguez (brief 2026 debuts):** these players are controlled through roughly 2032, so a five-year deal covers only pre-arbitration and arbitration seasons — to reach a free-agent year the deal must run seven or eight years. My estimate: five-year deals in the ~$20–30M range that simply smooth the arbitration years, or longer deals if the player wants the security.
- **Taj Bradley (2.097 service, free agency after 2030):** a five-year deal would reach his first free-agent year.
- **Connor Prielipp (0.000 service):** like Jenkins, controlled deep into the 2030s.

The analytics point for your class: a pre-arbitration extension is an insurance contract. The club takes on injury and decline risk in exchange for cost certainty and a discount on the free-agent years; the player takes guaranteed money in exchange for capping his upside. The two sides are exchanging risks — the deal is not necessarily an even split of expected dollars, and it is not itself a source of wins. It creates future financial flexibility, nothing more.

- **What about extending players before they reach the majors, as you envisioned?** The honest answer is that for players like Houston or Lackey the club already controls them well beyond the three-year window, so a pre-debut extension buys almost nothing for 2027–29 except cost certainty on seasons the Twins already controls. Its real value would be goodwill and locking in the 2030s, at the price of guaranteeing money to players who have never faced major-league pitching. My recommendation: wait until the debut.

B4. Sign free agents whose contracts span the whole window — relievers first.
The 2026–27 reliever class is unusually strong, and lefty JoJo Romero was named by Twins beat coverage as the target (Yahoo Sports, Yahoo Sports). A two- or three-year deal for Romero (my estimate, ~$4M per year) fits the window exactly. Do not sign any free agent over ~30 to more than two years. **Alternative use of the same money:** Padres lefty Adrian Morejon (28, 2.83 ERA in 86 innings in 2026) on a three-year deal, if you prefer the higher-ceiling arm (Yahoo Sports).

B5. Other young trade targets (alternatives, not all at once):

- **Xavier Edwards, 2B, Marlins** — arbitration through 2029 at just ~$3.5M; Miami listened at the deadline (Bleacher Report). Solves second base cheaply for the whole window.
- **Shea Langeliers, C, Athletics** — controlled through 2028 at ~$8.7M, if the Jeffers succession needs a bridge before Lackey/Diaw (Bleacher Report).
- A reunion with **Griffin Jax, SP, Rays** is possible but note his control ends after 2027 — a one-year fit unless extended (Bleacher Report).
- Do not pursue the premium chips (CJ Abrams, Zach Neto, Ronald Acuña Jr.) — the analysts' assessed costs would gut the very core this strategy is built around (Bleacher Report).

B6. Handle Jeffers by branch.
If the QO is extended and he declines, take the comp pick and hand catching to Caratini plus a cheap veteran or an early Diaw/Tait audition. If he accepts, the one-year salary likely above $20M does not fit this strategy's ledger either — the plan would be to immediately trade him (a productive catcher on a one-year deal has trade value), but I have not verified the consent rules that apply to players who accept a qualifying offer, so I would only extend the QO if the front office is comfortable trading an accepted contract. The alternative is to skip the QO and accept the risk of losing him for nothing.

B7. Clear the runway.
Give Rodriguez, Jenkins, and Keaschall 500+ at-bats each in 2027. The rotation keeps Kremer and Ober and loses only Ryan's slot: Prielipp, Matthews, and Abel compete for it (Detmers takes it if acquired, which then makes Ober or Kremer tradeable for prospects mid-season). Plan Houston's arrival for 2028 and Lackey's for 2029, with Culpepper shifting to second base when Houston arrives (Yardbarker).

B8. Sell at the 2027 deadline if needed.
If the club is out of the race in July 2027, flip López (if healthy and rebuilt value) and any other expiring deals for prospects — exactly the pattern of the 2025 fire sale, but this time from choice rather than distress.

The payroll path (my construction, full accounting)

Move	Payroll effect
Status-quo 2027 baseline	~$126M
Trade Ryan	−$9.6M
Acquire Detmers	+$7.5M
Sign Romero	+$4M
Extension increments in 2027 (illustrative schedule: Jenkins ~$1M above his minimum, Bradley ~$1M above arb, Keaschall ~$1M; all back-loaded)	+$3M
Total	**~$130.9M — approximately at the ~$131M ceiling**

Same caveats as Strategy A: approximately budget-targeted, ±$2M of slot-displacement slack. 2028: López and Hoffman (~$29M gross) come off, Houston arrives, the extended core is a year better, and roughly half the runoff is spendable on one significant addition. 2029: Buxton and the Correa payment (~$25M gross) come off, Lackey and Tait are options, and the core (Jenkins 23, Rodriguez 25, Keaschall 26, Culpepper 25, Bradley 28) enters its prime. That staged handoff is the strategy's engine: the money arrives in stages as the talent does.

Risks

Prospect development is the riskiest currency in baseball — for every Jenkins there is a Lewis (Royce Lewis's stalled career is the in-house cautionary tale). The catching surplus could evaporate if none of Lackey/Tait/Diaw/Tinney hits. The cheapness that makes the strategy viable could also cause ownership to pocket the 2028 savings rather than reinvest. And the strategy asks fans to accept a 2027 with a lower floor.

Probability of success (judgment estimate — not a model)

1. **2027.** Start from the same 82–85 win status quo as Strategy A (young-core growth already included). The Ryan-for-Detmers swap costs about a win; Romero adds a bit; the extensions add nothing on the field in 2027. Result: roughly an **81–84 win team** — P(playoffs) ≈ 30–40%, **P(AL pennant) ≈ 3–4%.**
2. **2028.** About half of ~$29M in expirations is spendable plus Houston's arrival; if two or three of the young players develop as hoped, this is an **87–89 win talent** — pennant ≈ 5–7%.
3. **2029.** The core enters its prime, Lackey is an option, and about half of another ~$25M rolls off — an **88–90 win ceiling if things break right** — pennant ≈ 6–8%.
4. **P(at least one pennant in 2027–29).** Under independence, 1 − (0.965 × 0.945 × 0.93) ≈ **15%**; stated range **12–16%** — with much wider error bars than Strategy A, because the projection rests on prospect development rather than established major-league performance, and with the same caveat that positive correlation across seasons trims the "at least one" probability below the independent calculation.

4. Side-by-Side Summary

Dimension	Strategy A: Go For It Now	Strategy B: Build the Three-Year Core
Headline additions	Trade for Goodman; sign Bednar; sign Romero	Trade Ryan (for prospects); trade for Detmers; extend Jenkins/Keaschall/Culpepper/Rodriguez/Bradley; sign Romero
Headline departures	Jeffers (QO), Larnach, Ober, Kremer, plus Tait/Quick/Mercedes in trade	Jeffers (QO), Ryan; Mendez plus the Ryan-return prospects in the Detmers trade
2027 projected wins (my estimate)	~86–88	~81–84
2027 pennant probability	~5–8%	~3–4%
3-year pennant probability (2027–29)	~12–16%	~12–16%
2028–29 outlook	Bednar/Goodman retained; Ryan and López contracts end; farm thinner	~$29M (2028) and ~$25M (2029) roll off in stages as Houston/Lackey arrive; farm intact

Dimension	Strategy A: Go For It Now	Strategy B: Build the Three-Year Core
Downside scenario	Buxton/López injuries, Goodman regresses, 80–84 wins with an empty farm	Prospects stall, money saved but never reinvested
Closest historical model	2015 Blue Jays; the Correa-era Twins pushes	Tampa Bay Rays (2026 pennant winner)

The striking result — and I want to flag it rather than bury it — is that **the two strategies' three-year pennant probabilities are essentially indistinguishable within my (wide) error bars.** Strategy A front-loads its chance into 2027; Strategy B trades that for a higher, longer plateau in 2028–29 with more variance. The genuine difference is in the shape of the risk, not obviously in the expected outcome. That is precisely the kind of finding that should generate spirited discussion in your classroom — and I want to be clear that this near-tie is a property of my assumptions, not a fact of nature; a more optimistic view of the young core's growth, for instance, would tilt it toward B.

5. Questions for Class Discussion

1. **Time preference:** Is a 6% chance of a pennant next year worth more to a fanbase (or an owner) than a 15% chance spread over three years? What does the answer depend on — the age of the fanbase, ownership's time horizon, revenue?
2. **The Rays problem:** Tampa Bay just won the AL pennant with a bottom-five payroll. Does that prove Strategy B is right, or does it prove that the Rays' specific development machine is not reproducible in Minnesota? What would you have to believe to copy it?
3. **The payroll bridge:** Why doesn't "$20 million more" mean "$20 million for free agents"? Walk through the arbitration raises and the roster-fill costs. How does this explain why so many "we signed a star!" offseasons disappoint?
4. **The extension gamble:** Would you guarantee a 21-year-old with a half-season of major-league at-bats (Jenkins) $70 million? What information does the club lack? What does the player give up? (Compare Corbin Carroll's deal, signed after 32 games.)
5. **The Jeffers qualifying offer:** If the QO is ~$22M and Jeffers's open-market value is ~$14M per year, what has to be true about his acceptance probability for the QO to be the right expected-value play — and what should the Twins do in each branch?
6. **Selling the core:** Would you trade Emmanuel Rodriguez plus two prospects for one year of Logan Gilbert (the published B/R proposal)? What does one marginal regular-season win trade for in prospect value — and what does that imply about the efficiency of win-now trades generally?
7. **Star power vs. depth:** Playoff series are famously noisy relative to regular-season talent gaps. If October outcomes are only loosely tied to how good your team was in the summer, what does that say about how much you should pay for the marginal win that gets you into October versus the marginal "proven October star"?
8. **The Moneyball echo:** The 2025 Twins fire sale and 2026 retool look a lot like the Oakland cycles your course has studied. What did the A's never do that the Rays now do routinely —

and did the 2002–03 Twins under Terry Ryan actually run a proto-Rays build (Santana, Hunter, Mauer, Morneau) without anyone calling it analytics?

References

The claims above trace to these sources. One exception flagged honestly: item 29 (The Athletic's top-40 free agent ranking) is paywalled and I could not read it directly; I include it only as background reading for those with access, and no claim above rests on it. Everything else was consulted in preparing this brief.

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